Russell Domingo, our coach, was absolutely correct to tell the squad over and over again that no one is irreplaceable, but our challenge was to cope with the absence of three stalwart legends, not just one.

Our margins for error seemed to have disappeared and it felt as though, if we were to prosper, we would need almost all our experienced players to perform well at the same time. If the frontline batsmen failed or if the frontline bowlers lost their line and rhythm, we would quite quickly find ourselves in trouble.

England were encouraged by a recent Ashes win over Australia, and Alastair Cook's squad arrived with what was perhaps then the strongest pace bowling attack in the world: there were fitness doubts over Jimmy Anderson, but he and Stuart Broad, supported by Steven Finn and Chris Woakes, would cause problems for anyone.

The first Test started in Durban on Boxing Day. Dale was back to lead our attack and he gave us the ideal start, removing Cook and Hales. We were taking control at 49 for three, but Nick Compton and James Taylor batted well in difficult conditions and helped the tourists reach a respectable 303 all out.

Dean Elgar demonstrated his huge potential when he scored a fighting century in our reply and I made 49 in reasonable time, but we succumbed to Broad's seam bowling and Moeen Ali's off-breaks, and were eventually all out for 214. A first-innings deficit of 89 runs did not augur well on a tricky wicket.

Dane Piedt, our promising spinner, performed well to take five wickets in the England second innings, but Compton, Root, Taylor and Jonny Bairstow all scored runs as they gradually moved ahead in the game, eventually leaving us a target of 416 to win in the last innings.

We wanted to fight and we tried to fight. Stiaan van Zyl and Dean Elgar both looked in decent form, but neither was able to go on and score the big hundred that we needed, and we were four wickets down at stumps on the fourth day.